

Unit 3 – Section 6: Managing Change & Contingency Planning

Exam Patterns & Trends (2019 – 2025)

Overview of Exam Patterns

Mark Type	Typical Command Words	Frequency	Focus Areas
4 marks	Define / Explain	Every Paper	Basic knowledge of change, risk, and planning terminology.
8 marks	Assess	Frequent	Causes of change, overcoming resistance, or risk management.
12 marks	Discuss	Frequent	Evaluation of change impact, leadership, and communication.
20 marks	Evaluate	Every Paper	Balanced discussion of adaptability, planning, and strategic resilience.

AO Weighting: AO1 (20%), AO2 (25%), AO3 (25%), AO4 (30%)

Topic Trend Analysis (2019 – 2025)

Topic	Year & Question Reference	Command Words	Trend Summary
Causes & Types of Change	2020 Jun Q2a, 2022 Jan Q3, 2023 Oct Q1a	Explain / Discuss	Frequently tested in 4–12 mark questions; focus on internal/external causes and incremental vs disruptive change.

Managing Resistance to Change	2019 Oct Q2b, 2021 Jun Q3, 2024 Jan Q2c	Explain / Evaluate	Common 8–20 mark topic focusing on Kotter & Schlesinger’s model and leadership style impact.
Contingency & Scenario Planning	2020 Oct Q3, 2022 Jun Q3a, 2024 Oct Q2d	Assess / Discuss	Increasing frequency; often 12–20 marks evaluating the value of preparation and crisis management.

Predicted Focus for Jan 2026 Exam

Predicted Topic	Mark	Command Word	Likely Context
Managing Resistance to Change	20	Evaluate	Evaluate whether resistance to change is always harmful to business performance.
Contingency Planning	12	Discuss	Discuss whether contingency planning is an effective use of resources for large businesses like Emirates.
Causes of Change	8	Assess	Assess the impact of technological change on modern businesses.
Scenario Planning	4	Explain	Explain one reason why scenario planning supports strategic decision-making.

Teacher Revision Tips

- Reinforce Kotter & Schlesinger's model for overcoming resistance (six strategies).
- Use real-world examples — e.g., Nokia, Blockbuster, and Netflix — to demonstrate responses to change.
- Link to Unit 3.3.4 (culture and leadership) for integrated essay preparation.
- Practise comparing proactive vs reactive responses to change.
- For 20-mark questions, stress long-term vs short-term analysis and stakeholder implications.

Key Takeaways

- Change management is tested in every Unit 3 exam, often in the 20-mark essay.
- Resistance to change and contingency planning have grown in frequency post-2021.
- Strong AO4 evaluation depends on context and realism — focus on feasibility and leadership.
- Scenario planning and adaptability are increasingly linked to strategic resilience.
- Jan 2026 likely to feature a 20-mark evaluation on change resistance or contingency planning.